Safety and Warranted Retraction of Epistemic-Modal Knowledge Claims

ARA-proposed thesis

Abstract

An assessment-sensitive retraction of an epistemic-modal knowledge claim is warranted only when the claim fails the nearby-world worldly-information safety condition; a later assessor's disagreement alone is insufficient. This criterion addresses a missing premise: a safety condition on knowledge does not, by itself, specify when a later retraction is warranted. The proposal concerns warranted retraction, not actual retraction, permission to retract, or obligatory withdrawal. The proposal does not infer an obligation to retract from safety failure; that would require a further normative assumption.

Introduction

The proposal is that, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, warranted assessment-sensitive retraction requires that the original belief fail nearby-world worldly-information safety as evaluated at the later assessment; a later assessor’s disagreement alone is insufficient. The proposal addresses a missing premise: a safety condition on knowledge does not, by itself, specify when a later retraction is warranted. Fixing the use context keeps evaluation directed at the earlier claim rather than replacing it with a new claim made at the later context. The proposal concerns warrant, not the fact of actual retraction, permission to retract, or obligatory withdrawal. The paper argues for a necessary criterion under stated assumptions, not an unrestricted biconditional or a reversal of a source’s sufficient retraction rule.

Beddor and Goldstein characterize information-sensitive safety as a condition on modal knowledge: at every nearby world where the belief is held, it must be true relative to the worldly information at that world (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). They also state that each possible world determines a special body of information relevant to knowing epistemic-modal claims (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). These claims supply a safety condition and the worldly-information notion, but do not themselves state a retraction norm. The move from a knowledge condition to a criterion of warranted retraction therefore requires an explicit normative assumption: safety failure is relevant to whether this earlier knowledge claim warrants correction. The proposal’s limited scope makes that bridge visible rather than attributing it to the source.

The bounded literature comparison motivates examination of this bridge but does not establish it. A bounded search with incomplete full-text access cannot establish either that the proposed link is absent from the literature or that the thesis is true. The dossier’s not-found framing is limited to the specified component and search scope; it does not establish that no support exists beyond that scope. These findings are not premises, verified novelty, source endorsements, or certification that the claim

is true or an open problem. The discussion will distinguish the proposed necessary condition from obligation, permission, actual withdrawal, and another speaker’s rejection, and will state where further assumptions would be needed.

Methodology

The thesis was proposed by ARA.

The proposal is that, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, an assessment-sensitive retraction of an epistemic-modal knowledge claim is warranted only when the original belief fails nearby-world worldly-information safety as evaluated at the later assessment; a later assessor’s disagreement alone is insufficient. This section’s method is to distinguish source commitments, the paper’s proposed bridge, and reasons for that bridge, rather than treating the bridge as a result mechanically derived from the sources.

Beddor and Goldstein formulate information-sensitive safety as a condition on modal knowledge: at every nearby world where the belief is held, it must be true relative to the worldly information at that world (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). They state that every possible world determines a body of information relevant to knowing epistemic-modal propositions (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). These claims supply the safety condition and the notion of worldly information, but do not themselves state when retraction is warranted. The transition from a knowledge condition to a retraction criterion therefore needs an explicitly paper-owned normative assumption.

MacFarlane states a retraction rule that requires retraction when a proposition is not true as used in the original context and assessed from the later context, and distinguishes the contexts of the original speech act and retraction (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). The paper argues that this rule is relevant background for separating use from assessment, but does not treat it as establishing the proposed safety criterion. Hawke considers a safety variant that drops a truth condition and discusses countermodels to features of that variant (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). This comparison cautions against identifying truth and safety, but does not establish a retraction norm. Rudin reports that participants may reject modal claims without judging them false (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). Another speaker’s rejection is not thereby the original speaker’s retrospective retraction obligation.

These comparisons keep distinct safety failure, assessment, truth, rejection, and retraction; they do not serve as premises proving the bridge. The literature comparison is bounded: the supplied 2018–2026 search reports a partial currency verdict, partial anticipation by Mighty Knowledge and Dinges (2021), inaccessible comparisons, and incomplete citation indexing. Its not-found framing applies only within that stated scope and does not certify novelty, truth, or an open problem.

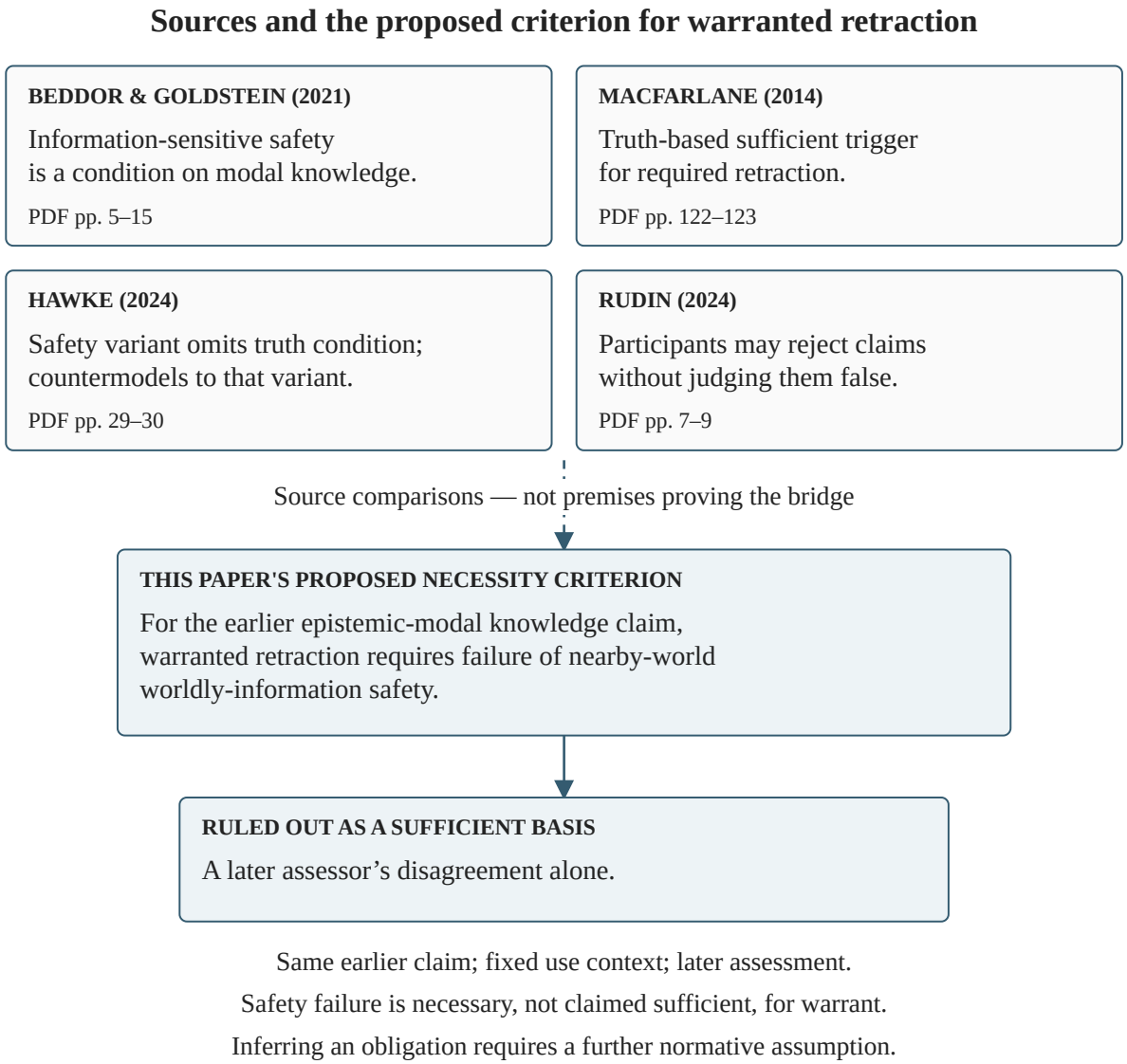


Figure 1. Source comparisons, the paper's proposed necessity criterion, and its limit on disagreement. The dashed connector marks background, not proof of the bridge. The criterion rejects later disagreement alone as a sufficient basis for warranted retraction; the footer states its direction and normative limits.

The proposed safety criterion and its rationale

Failure of nearby-world worldly-information safety is necessary for warranted assessment-sensitive retraction of the specified epistemic-modal knowledge claim, while later disagreement alone is insufficient. The proposal concerns whether retraction is warranted as a correction of the earlier claim, not whether a retraction actually occurs or whether withdrawal is obligatory. Keeping those questions distinct is essential to the scope of the criterion: its target is warrant, and it does not settle every possible ground for retracting a speech act.

The proposal relies on an explicit bridge assumption: for this specified knowledge claim, a correction is warranted only when the belief-making pattern relevant to the claim fails the nearby-world safety condition. The safety condition supplies a way to identify the relevant defect across nearby worlds by evaluating the belief in relation to worldly information there. The paper argues that, under the stated

assumption, failure of that condition is necessary for a warranted correction of the earlier knowledge claim. This is a proposed normative connection, not a conclusion mechanically obtained from the safety condition alone.

The limit on the role of disagreement follows from the same proposed criterion. Disagreement by a later assessor, without a relevant defect in the earlier claim, does not itself identify what about that claim merits correction. The criterion therefore does not treat the later assessor's different view as sufficient for warranted retraction. The central question is instead whether the earlier belief fails the safety condition when evaluated with the relevant worldly information at nearby worlds.

Retaining the earlier use context keeps the evaluation directed at the same claim across the change in assessment. The proposal concerns an assessment-sensitive retraction of that earlier claim, rather than a new claim made at the later assessment context. The paper argues that, on this framing, the later assessment provides the standpoint for evaluating the earlier claim, while the relevant defect condition remains failure of nearby-world worldly-information safety. Later disagreement alone does not replace that condition.

The proposal does not assert the converse direction: it does not claim that every safety failure is sufficient for warranted retraction. The paper argues that the stated criterion is a necessary condition, and that moving from failure of safety to warrant would require an additional assumption that such a failure is a relevant defect for this claim. Moving further from warrant to an obligation to retract would require a separate normative assumption connecting that warrant to required withdrawal. Neither additional step is supplied by the safety condition itself.

The proposal is limited to the specified class of epistemic-modal knowledge claims and does not determine all possible grounds for retracting speech acts. Its rationale depends on the stated bridge assumption about warranted correction, not on treating a later assessor's disagreement as an independent reason to retract. No model-alignment judgment functions here as a source endorsement or as a premise establishing the proposed criterion.

Warranted retraction of the specified earlier epistemic-modal knowledge claim requires failure of nearby-world worldly-information safety, while a later assessor's disagreement alone is insufficient. The word "requires" fixes the direction of the criterion: warranted retraction entails a relevant safety failure. It does not say that safety failure by itself guarantees warranted retraction. Preserving this direction matters because the proposed bridge adds a normative condition rather than deriving a retraction rule from the safety account alone.

Beddor and Goldstein state that information-sensitive safety is a condition on modal knowledge: at nearby worlds where the belief is held, it must be true relative to the worldly information at those worlds (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). They state that each possible world determines information relevant to knowing epistemic-modal propositions (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). These claims identify the safety condition's relevant materials, but do not themselves establish when a later correction is warranted. The proposed bridge uses failure of the condition to identify a

possible defect in the earlier belief-making pattern, while keeping the original use context fixed. The standpoint of later assessment does not, by itself, substitute the later assessor's information for the worldly information used in evaluating safety.

Disagreement alone does not identify such a defect: it reports a difference in assessment, not whether the earlier belief fails the condition. The criterion therefore makes safety evaluation, rather than disagreement itself, the stated requirement for warranted correction. This explains the limited force of the disagreement clause without claiming that disagreement can never accompany a warranted retraction. A safety failure must still be treated as relevant to correction of this particular claim; that is the normative assumption in the bridge, not a result supplied by the source's knowledge condition. The proposal neither settles every possible ground for retracting a speech act nor converts warrant into obligation. Asserting such an obligation would require a further assumption linking warranted correction to required withdrawal. Actual retraction remains a separate question from whether it is warranted.

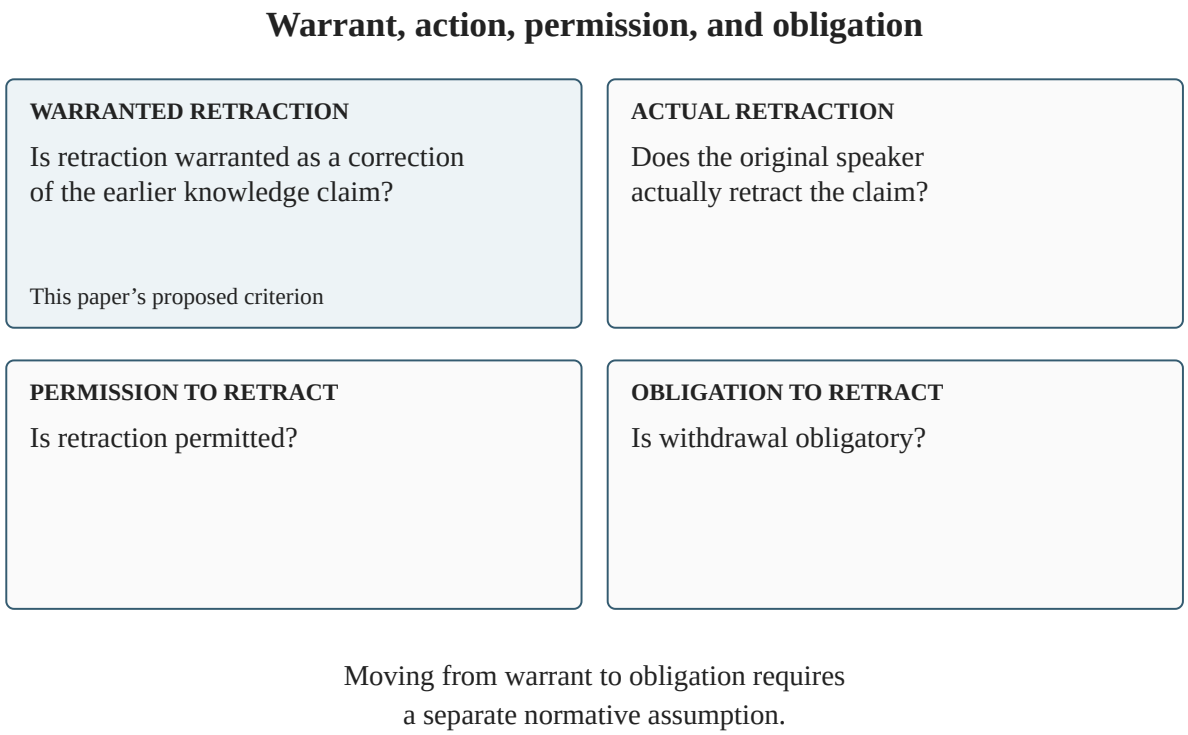


Figure 2. Four distinct questions about retraction. The highlighted question is the proposal's target: warranted correction. Actual retraction, permission, and obligation remain separate; inferring obligation from warrant requires the further assumption shown in the footer.

Objections, replies, and limits

This paper objects that a sufficient condition for required retraction cannot establish a necessary condition for warranted retraction. That rule states a sufficient trigger for required retraction; it does not state that a failure of nearby-world safety is necessary for warranted retraction (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). This paper replies that the present proposal does not derive its necessity claim by

reversing MacFarlane's conditional. The paper argues for a separate, narrower criterion concerning when retraction of the specified epistemic-modal knowledge claim is warranted. Its criterion is a separately proposed claim about warrant, not a conclusion established by the preceding sufficient-condition argument.

The proposal is that, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, warranted assessment-sensitive retraction requires failure of the nearby-world worldly-information safety condition as evaluated at the later assessment; a later assessor's disagreement alone is insufficient. This criterion addresses warrant for correcting the earlier claim, not whether the original speaker actually retracts it, whether retraction is permitted, or whether withdrawal is obligatory. Keeping those responses separate matters because evidence of a different person's rejection or a source's rule about required retraction does not, by itself, establish the proposed condition for warranted correction.

Hawke considers a safety variant that drops a truth condition and presents countermodels to features of that variant (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). This comparison cautions against silently identifying truth with safety, but does not decide whether safety failure is necessary for the proposed retraction criterion. Neither the variant nor its countermodels establish a norm for warranted retraction. The distinction between truth and safety must remain explicit, because the proposed criterion needs its own normative bridge.

Rudin reports that participants may be willing to reject epistemic-modal claims they do not judge false (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). This paper replies that another participant's rejection and the original speaker's warranted retrospective retraction are distinct responses. The reported divergence does not decide whether the earlier belief fails the relevant safety condition. The finding therefore supplies neither a safety test nor a retraction rule for the proposal. It does, however, make it important not to treat rejection as interchangeable with judging a claim false or with retracting one's own earlier assertion.

This paper objects that a later assessor might disagree even while the earlier belief remains safe relative to the relevant worldly information. This paper replies that the proposal explicitly denies that disagreement alone is sufficient for warranted retraction. The relevant question, under the proposal, is whether the earlier belief fails nearby-world worldly-information safety as assessed from the later context. A difference in assessment does not itself answer that question. Fixing the earlier use context keeps the evaluation directed at the same claim rather than substituting a new claim made at the later context.

The criterion does not claim that every safety failure obliges the speaker to retract. Moving from safety failure to required withdrawal would need an additional norm connecting that failure to an obligation to retract. The proposed necessary condition for warrant leaves that further question open; it does not turn a criterion for warranted correction into a rule of obligatory withdrawal. The criterion is limited to the specified earlier epistemic-modal knowledge claim and does not settle every possible ground for retracting a speech act.

The bounded dossier comparison reports partial anticipation and incomplete or inaccessible comparisons, so its not_found result applies only within the stated search scope. The dossier does not certify novelty or establish the proposed thesis. Neither the bounded search nor the cited comparisons should be treated as premises proving the criterion. Its proposal is a limited, separately argued bridge: safety failure is necessary for the specified warranted retraction, and later assessor disagreement alone is insufficient.

Conclusion

The paper proposes a limited bridge: for the specified earlier epistemic-modal knowledge claim, warranted assessment-sensitive retraction requires failure of nearby-world worldly-information safety, and a later assessor's disagreement alone is insufficient. The bridge makes explicit the normative assumption needed to move from a safety condition on knowledge to a criterion for warranted correction: safety failure must count as a relevant defect in the earlier claim. This assumption belongs to the paper's proposal, not to a mechanically derived source conclusion.

Beddor and Goldstein characterize information-sensitive safety as a condition on modal knowledge and state that each possible world determines information relevant to knowing epistemic-modal claims (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15) (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). These claims provide the safety condition and worldly-information notion, but do not themselves establish a retraction criterion. MacFarlane states a rule requiring retraction under a specified truth condition (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). The proposal does not reverse that rule to derive necessity. Hawke distinguishes truth from safety in considering a variant that drops the truth condition (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). The comparison cautions against conflating truth and safety, without deciding the proposed criterion. Rudin reports that participants may reject modal claims without judging them false (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). Another person's rejection is distinct from the original speaker's warranted retrospective retraction.

The proposal concerns warrant, not actual retraction, permission to retract, or an obligation to withdraw. The paper argues that the bounded 2018–2026 search has a partial currency verdict, including partial anticipation by Mighty Knowledge and Dinges (2021), and that its not-found framing applies only within that search scope. The external findings motivate the question but are not premises, endorsements, verified novelty, or certification that the proposal is true or an open problem. No model-alignment judgment supplies a premise for this conclusion.

Status and method

The external AI findings motivate the question but are not premises, verified novelty, or source endorsements. A bounded, incomplete search cannot establish either that the proposed link is absent from the literature or that the thesis is true. Limiting a not-found claim to its stated search scope matters: failure to locate support within that scope does not show that no support exists or certify novelty, truth, or an open problem.

The thesis was proposed by ARA. The bridge principle connecting safety failure to warranted retraction is argued in this paper; it is not mechanically derived from the cited sources.

References

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